YOUN BAEK

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EMPLOYMENT

Department of Management & Organizations, NYU Stern *2025 - Present*
Endless Frontier Labs
Postdoctoral Researcher
Supervisor: Deepak Hegde

EDUCATION

NYU Stern *2019 - 2025*
Ph.D. in Economics

Korea University *2018*
M.A. in Economics

Korea University *2016*
B.B.A. in Business Administration

Arizona State University *2016*
Semester abroad

INTERESTS

Research Interests: Entrepreneurship, Innovation, Strategy
Secondary: Political Economy, Development Economics

RESEARCH

Job market paper

Do Venture Capitalists Venture? [Draft coming soon]

Proximity to other innovators may enable them to learn from one another, but it can also crowd them around the same ideas. This paper asks whether such convergence can go beyond valuable learning and reflect costly herding in the context of venture capital. I measure VCs' investment similarity as the semantic proximity between textual descriptions of a focal startup and other recently funded startups. Then I investigate the influence of peer investors active in the same geography–industry cell, using variation in their investment behavior outside the focal geography and industry. Peer-induced investment similarity lowers VC financial returns, slows startup revenue growth, and leads startups to produce fewer, less influential, and more derivative patents. Investors respond more strongly to network-central peers, even though following them predicts worse returns. Specialized peers attenuate these losses but do not eliminate them. Nor does imitation create offsetting benefits for VCs by improving the performance of their other portfolio startups or their subsequent investments. While the costs of herding fall on limited partners, VCs who herd most deploy more capital and become more central in future syndication networks.

Working papers

Beyond Demo Day: Sorting and Value Added in Startup Accelerators (with Deepak Hegde) [Draft] *Submitted*

Startup accelerators have become one of the most prominent intermediaries in entrepreneurial finance. Yet, their value is hard to measure because they select the ventures they serve. We link 742,000 U.S. startups to 329 accelerators and adapt the teacher value-added framework to estimate accelerator value added (AVA) net of sorting. Selection is systematic: stronger ventures sort into higher-AVA programs. Accelerator effectiveness is dispersed: against a matched no-accelerator counterfactual, most programs have negative value added in point estimates, while a small right tail generates large gains. High-AVA accelerators predict better long-run outcomes and faster exit of weaker ventures.

Industrial Spillovers from Agricultural Processing: Evidence from the Beet Sugar Industry [Draft] Forthcoming at ***Journal of Urban Economics***

Missionaries and the Birth of International Development [Draft] Presented at [NBER Summer Institute] *Submitted*

Works in progress

Estimating VC value add (with Deepak Hegde)
We apply the teacher value-added framework from education economics to measure the contribution of venture capital investors to startup growth. We show that differences in investment strategies across VC investors account for a substantial share of the dispersion in investment performance. The estimated value-added measures exhibit strong out-of-sample predictive power, particularly in settings where investors are expected to play an active value-adding role—such as lead investments, first financing rounds, and early-stage deals—but are considerably less predictive in later-stage or passive investments. Finally, exploiting the movement of investment partners across venture capital firms, we show that the majority of investor value added is attributable to individual partners rather than the VC firms with which they are affiliated, highlighting the importance of partner-specific human capital in venture capital investing.

Estimating the supply elasticity of innovation [Draft]

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Undergraduate:	Microeconomics with Algebra, Microeconomics with Calculus (Spring 2021, Fall 2021, Spring 2022, Fall 2022, Spring 2023, Fall 2023, Spring 2024) Teaching assistant: Prof. Guillaume Haeringer, Prof. Gianluca Clementi, Prof. Simon Bowmaker, Prof. Tommaso Denti, Prof. Jacob French
MBA:	Firms and Markets (Fall 2021, Spring 2022) Teaching assistant: Prof. Maher Said, Prof. Simon Bowmaker Economics of Creativity and Innovation (Fall 2021) Teaching assistant: Prof. Petra Moser

FELLOWSHIPS AND AWARDS

2025: AI at Work research grant, Schmidt Sciences. **2024**: Adam Smith Fellowship, Mercatus Center. **2023**: Kurnow PhD Fellowship, New York University. **2019**: Doctoral Fellowship, Ilju Academic Foundation; Doctoral Fellowship, Kwanjeong Educational Foundation (declined); Doctoral Fellowship, NYU Stern. **2015**: Undergraduate Fellowship, Korea Foundation for Advanced Studies.

PRESENTATIONS

2025: NBER Summer Institute (political economy); Society for Institutional Organizational Economics (UNSW); Wharton AI and the Future of Work conference (poster); Laboratory for the Economics of Africa's Past (Stellenbosch); Northwestern Kellogg Political Economy Rookiefest; Pacific Conference for Development Economics (PacDev); Association for the Study of Religion, Economics, and Culture Conference (ASREC) **2023**: North American Meeting of the Urban Economics Association **2021**: Yale Economic History Graduate Student Conference

**Scheduled*

OTHER

Languages: English (fluent), Korean (native)

Last updated: August 28, 2026